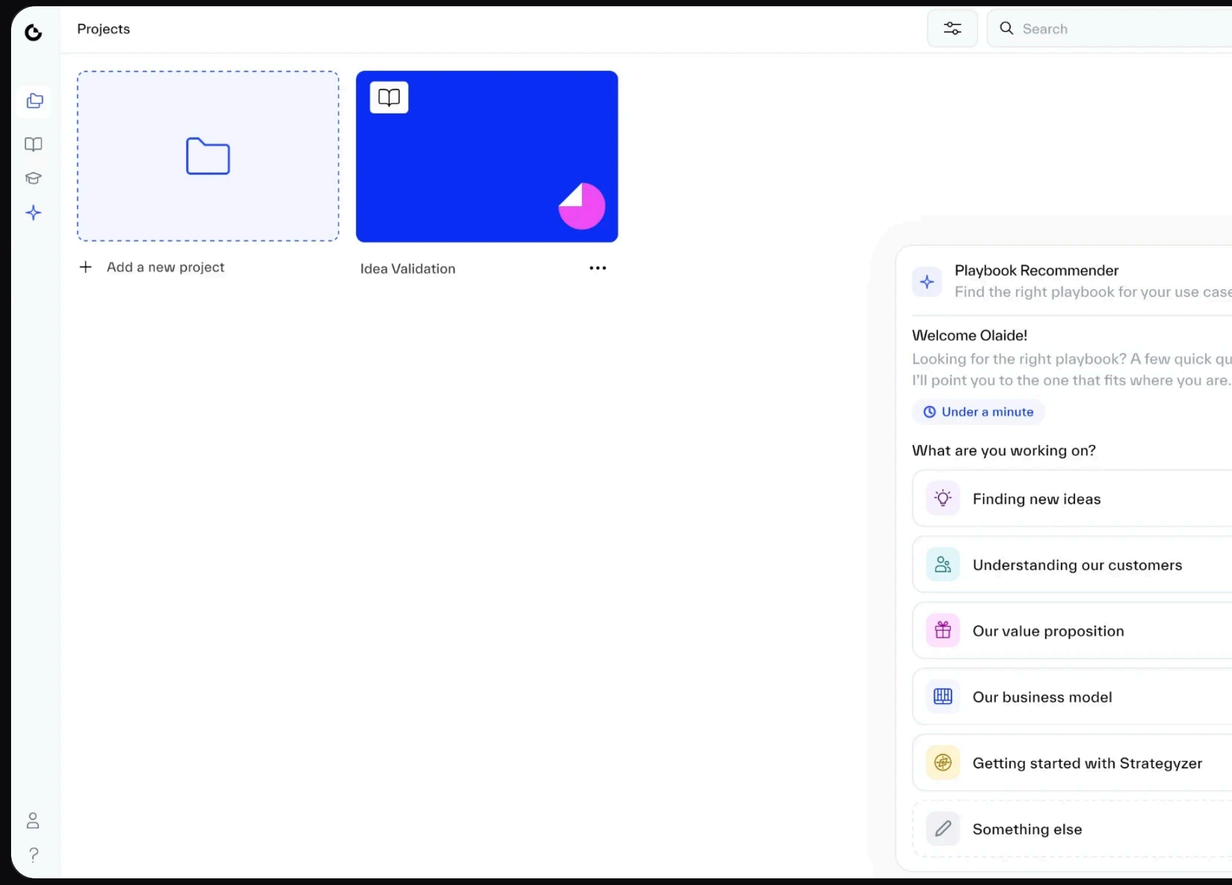
OLAIDE ARIKE KAFFO · STRATEGYZER CASE STUDY

Solving the first-step problem

We set out to build an AI assistant. I made the case to ship a three-question Playbook Recommender first, and it moved every number that mattered.



ROLE

Senior product designer, and the only designer

TEAM

Head of Product, one engineer, coaching and customer teams

TIMELINE

About 6 weeks, spring 2026

STATUS

Live

THE PROBLEM

New customers got stuck on their first choice.

43%

of new customers never started a project.

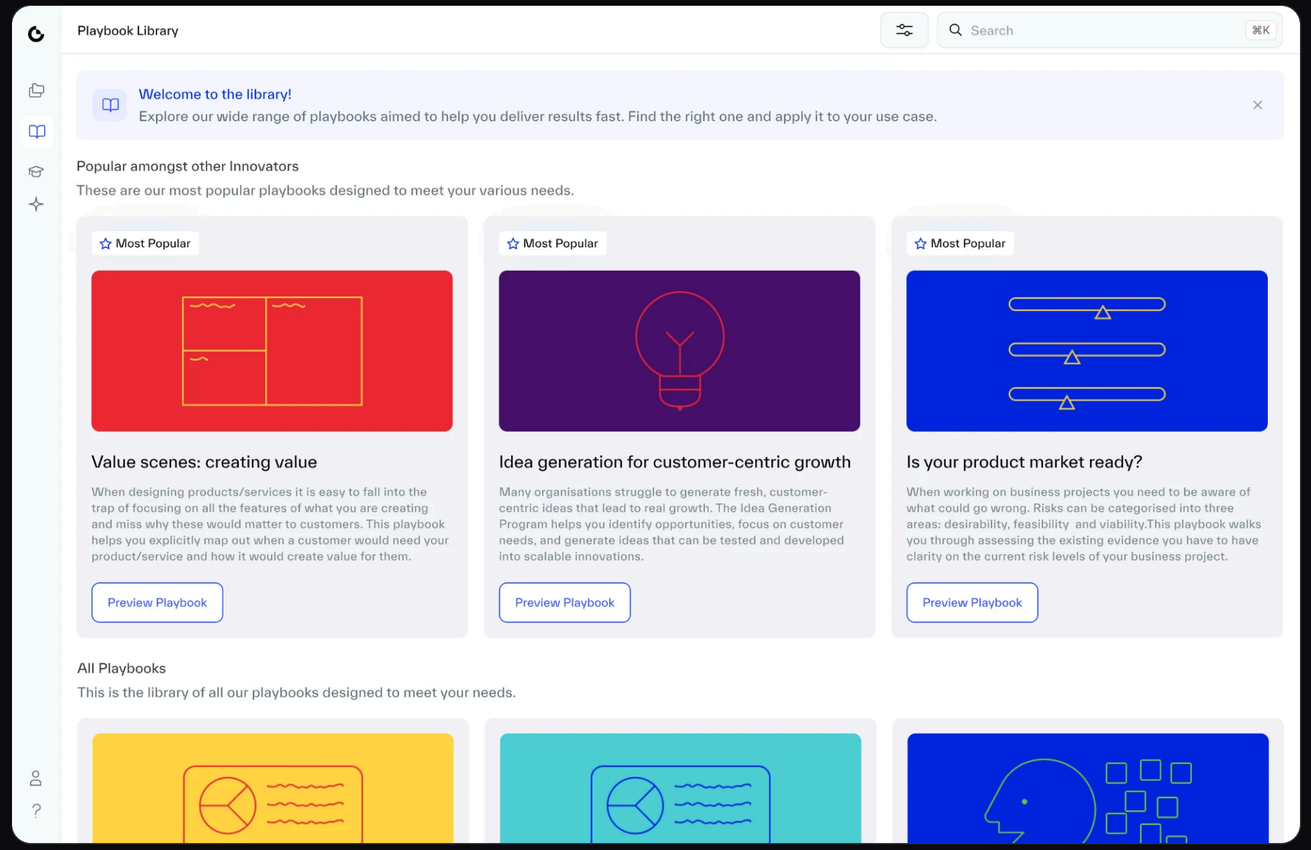
They came with a real business problem, found a library of playbooks, and couldn't tell which one was right for them. Each playbook takes hours, so picking the wrong one wastes that time. People hesitated, guessed or gave up.

ENTERPRISE

Guided by a coach, who asks two or three questions and says start here.

SELF-SERVE

Left alone with the full library, just when they know the least.



A wall of options. Long descriptions, then the whole library, and nothing to say which one fits their problem.

RESEARCH

Eight customer interviews, plus our customer success and coaching teams.

GROUP ONE

Solo founders

Testing an idea before pitching investors. New to Strategyzer's terms.

GROUP TWO

Heads of strategy and innovation

Testing an idea before presenting to senior leaders, often with half the work already done.

BOTH GROUPS

Very different people, the same problem

- Too many ideas
- No clear first step
- An important meeting coming up

In every conversation, the most common complaint was choosing a playbook. Even our own coaches said it.

If our coaches found it hard, the problem was in the product. Returning customers faced the same choice every time they started something new.

Customers were asking for AI, so we started there.

Strattie AI was an assistant across the whole platform, like having a Strategyzer coach beside you at every step. I designed it and built a working prototype with Claude, using FondUI, our design system.

A coach you could chat with

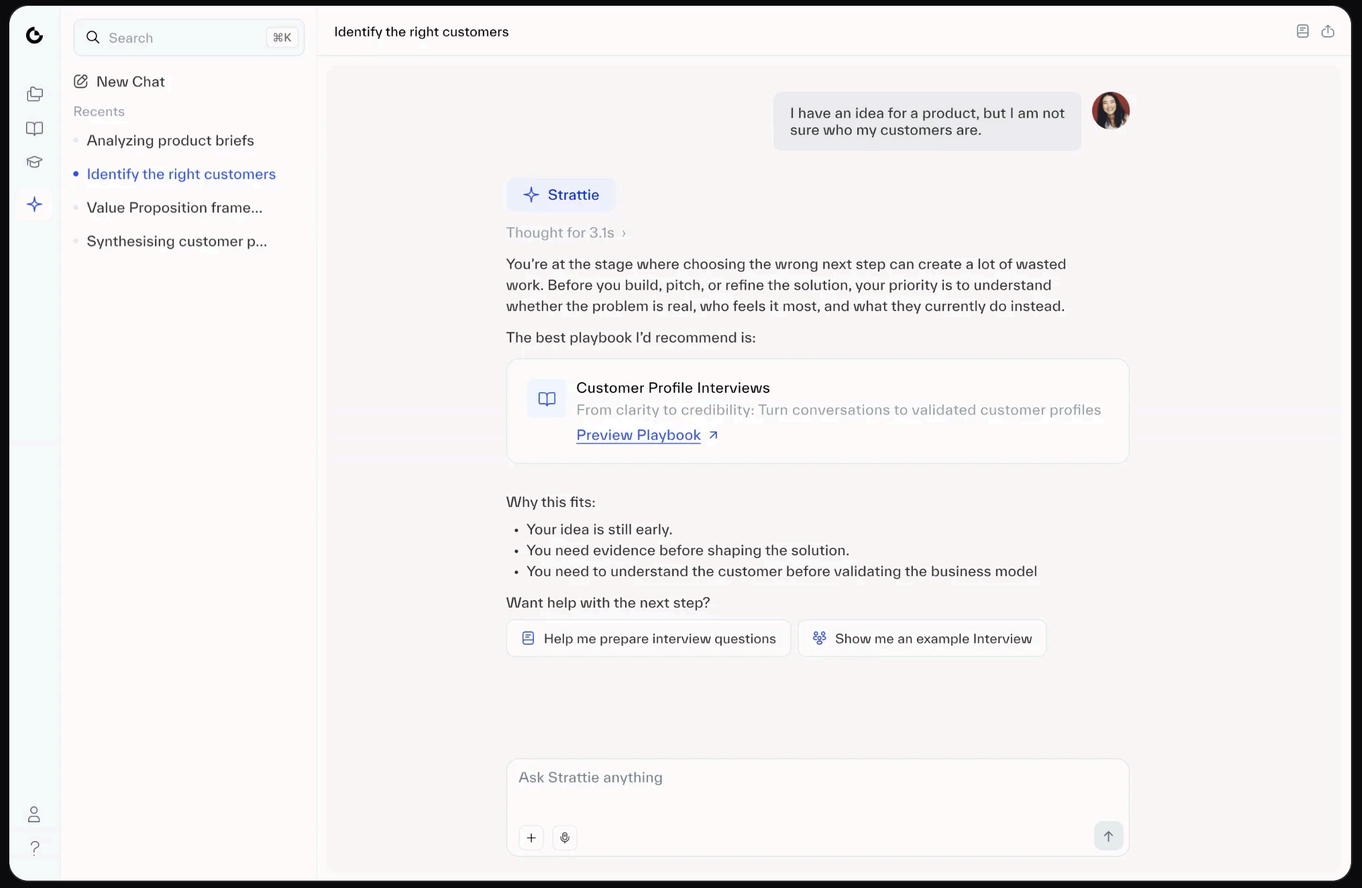
On every page and aware of your project. It helped people shape ideas, brainstorm and challenge their thinking.

Help on the canvas

Summarising work, pointing to evidence, checking ideas, drafting sticky notes.

Recommending playbooks

One of its many jobs.



The full assistant, start to finish. From a playbook recommendation to interview questions, a customer profile and a finished workspace. Fully prototyped, and not in the first release.

WHAT THE PROTOTYPE TAUGHT US

Building it for real showed three things a static design would have hidden.

01

The value was in the questions.

A good coach asks two or three questions before recommending anything. In an open chat, the assistant often answered before it had asked them.

02

Doing it well was a much bigger job than it looked.

Vague requests, a changing library and knowing when to say "I don't know" were more than our small team could take on at the time.

03

Chat is the wrong tool for "where do I start?"

People came to us because they couldn't put their problem into words. A chat box asks them to do exactly that.

THE REFRAME

Engineering couldn't build the full assistant in the time frame we needed. The team's first instinct, a fair one, was to build a smaller version of it.

I pushed back.

A smaller chatbot is just a worse chatbot.

	SMALLER CHATBOT	GUIDED RECOMMENDER
Designing the conversation	Still needed in full	■ A few fixed questions
Recommending playbooks that don't exist	Still possible	■ Not possible
Describing the problem	People have to type it	■ People pick from options
Shows whether guidance helps	Not clearly	■ Yes

SO I CHANGED THE QUESTION

~~What's the smallest assistant we can build?~~ →

What's the one job that matters most right now?

One job came first every time. Finding the right playbook is where every new project starts, and where people kept getting stuck.

MAKING THE CASE

I took the prototype and my research to our CEO and Head of Product.

Our Head of Product was keen on the assistant. On a call, I showed them the working prototype and my research. Every group we spoke to needed the same thing, help choosing where to start.

THE PUSHBACK

Customers were asking for AI, and a set of guided questions could look like we were falling behind.

MY ANSWER

I wasn't against AI. The platform will need it. But choosing a playbook comes first. **If people get stuck there, they'll leave before they ever see an AI feature.** Fix that first, and every AI feature we add later reaches people who are already getting value.

DECISION

Ship the Recommender first. The assistant comes next.

THE TRADE-OFF

It was a trade-off, and I made it knowingly.

WHAT IT BOUGHT US

Only real playbooks

It can only recommend playbooks that exist.

Honest when nothing fits

It says so instead of guessing.

Faster than typing

Three taps instead of explaining a problem you can't yet put into words.

Less risk

It proved guidance helps before we invested in the full assistant.

WHAT IT COST · MOVED TO A LATER RELEASE

The full assistant

Help on the canvas

which our coaches had asked for

The chat panel

The onboarding tour

That was hard to let go of. I'd rather ship one job done well than several half-done.

A small panel people come back to.

1

A small panel in the corner

I tried three shapes. A pop-up covered the library, and a tall side panel looked like a chat that wasn't there. The corner panel kept the page usable.

2

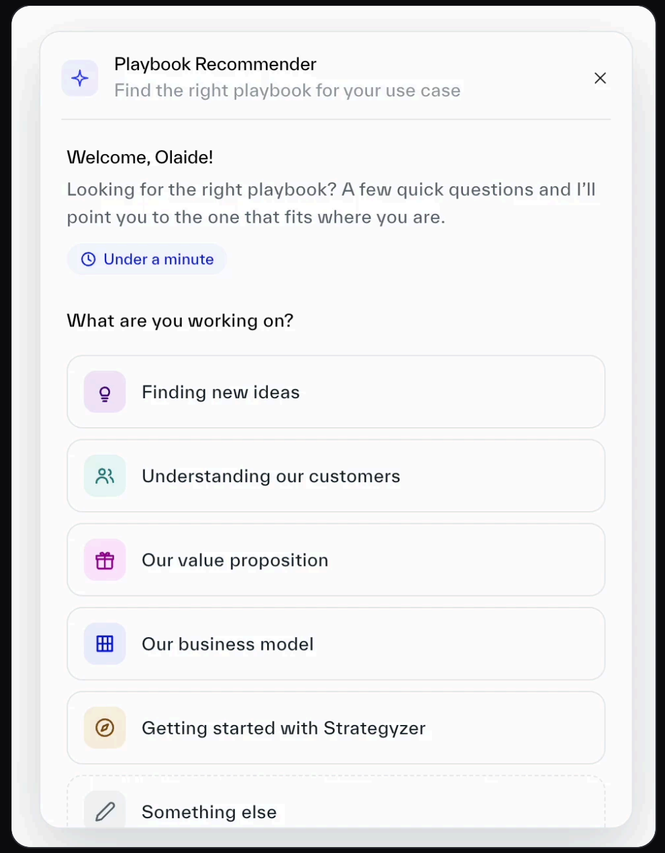
Answers shrink as you go

Borrowed from Asana's AI menu. Each answer shrinks to a short message, so the panel stays short.

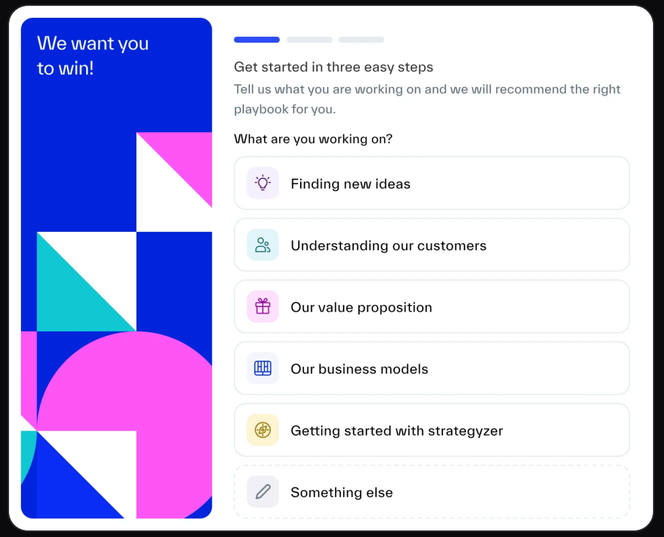
3

Built to return to

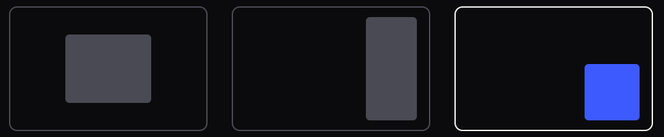
I dropped the tour-style version I explored first. People come back to this whenever they're stuck.



Shipped. Three questions to a recommendation, recorded in the working prototype.



Explored first. The tour-style version, with its progress bar and big welcome screen.



Pop-up in the middle

Tall side panel

Small corner panel

The questions come from research, mapped by hand.

5 PROBLEM AREAS → **17** GOALS → **45** PATHS → **19** PLAYBOOKS

4

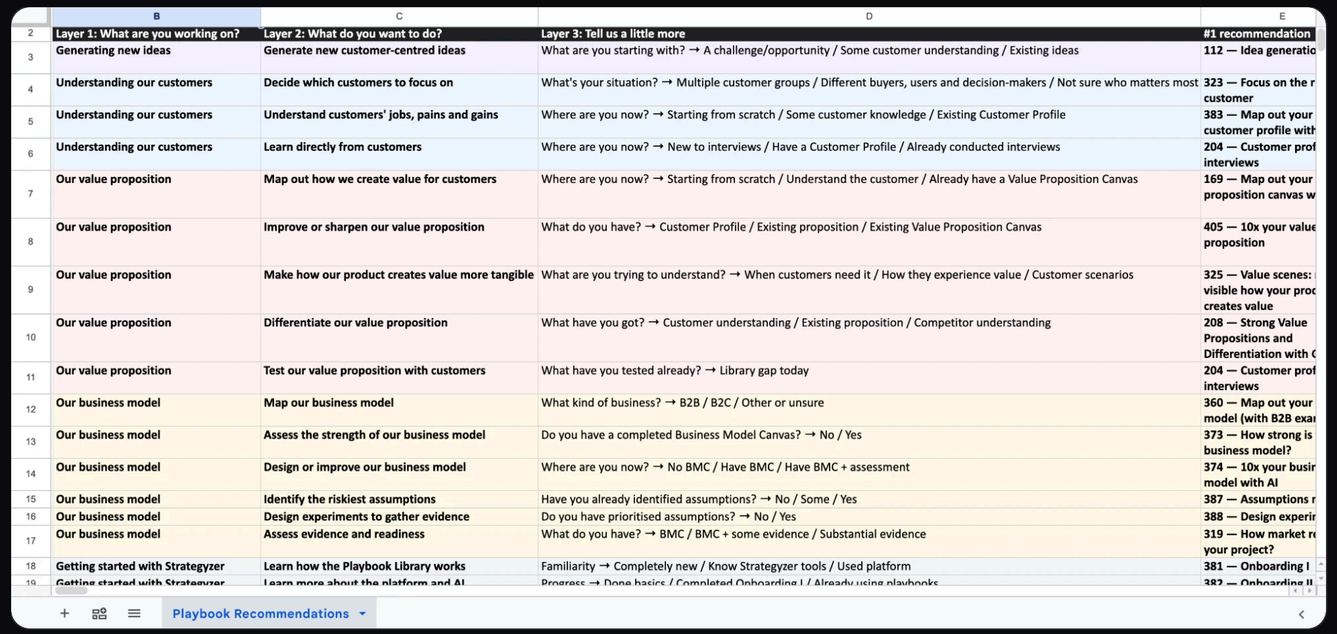
Written down, so we can trust it and fix it

I built the map in two days from how customers described their situations. It isn't generated by AI, so when a path is wrong we can see it and correct it.

5

Questions anyone can answer

Question one asks what you're working on in everyday words, for founders new to Strategyzer. Question three only appears when it changes the answer, so people with work done can skip ahead.

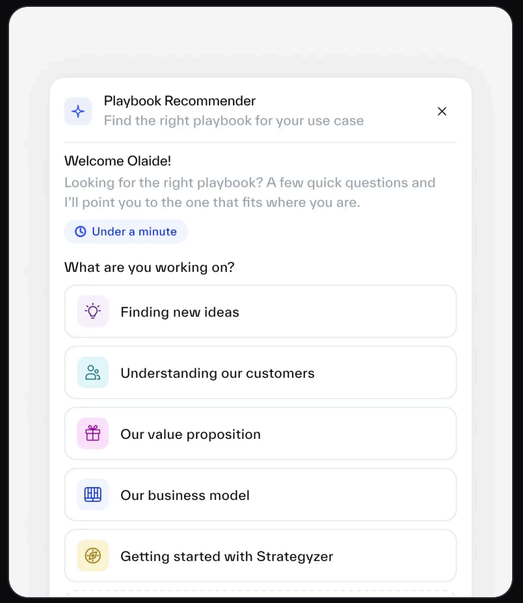


	B	C	D	E
2	Layer 1: What are you working on?	Layer 2: What do you want to do?	Layer 3: Tell us a little more	#1 recommendation
3	Generating new ideas	Generate new customer-centred ideas	What are you starting with? → A challenge/opportunity / Some customer understanding / Existing ideas	112 — Idea generatio
4	Understanding our customers	Decide which customers to focus on	What's your situation? → Multiple customer groups / Different buyers, users and decision-makers / Not sure who matters most	323 — Focus on the r customer
5	Understanding our customers	Understand customers' jobs, pains and gains	Where are you now? → Starting from scratch / Some customer knowledge / Existing Customer Profile	383 — Map out your customer profile with
6	Understanding our customers	Learn directly from customers	Where are you now? → New to interviews / Have a Customer Profile / Already conducted interviews	204 — Customer prof interviews
7	Our value proposition	Map out how we create value for customers	Where are you now? → Starting from scratch / Understand the customer / Already have a Value Proposition Canvas	169 — Map out your proposition canvas w
8	Our value proposition	Improve or sharpen our value proposition	What do you have? → Customer Profile / Existing proposition / Existing Value Proposition Canvas	405 — 10x your value proposition
9	Our value proposition	Make how our product creates value more tangible	What are you trying to understand? → When customers need it / How they experience value / Customer scenarios	325 — Value scenes: visible how your proc creates value
10	Our value proposition	Differentiate our value proposition	What have you got? → Customer understanding / Existing proposition / Competitor understanding	208 — Strong Value Propositions and Differentiation with C
11	Our value proposition	Test our value proposition with customers	What have you tested already? → Library gap today	204 — Customer prof interviews
12	Our business model	Map our business model	What kind of business? → B2B / B2C / Other or unsure	360 — Map out your model (with B2B exa
13	Our business model	Assess the strength of our business model	Do you have a completed Business Model Canvas? → No / Yes	373 — How strong is business model?
14	Our business model	Design or improve our business model	Where are you now? → No BMC / Have BMC / Have BMC + assessment	374 — 10x your busir model with AI
15	Our business model	Identify the riskiest assumptions	Have you already identified assumptions? → No / Some / Yes	387 — Assumptions r
16	Our business model	Design experiments to gather evidence	Do you have prioritised assumptions? → No / Yes	388 — Design experir
17	Our business model	Assess evidence and readiness	What do you have? → BMC / BMC + some evidence / Substantial evidence	319 — How market re your project?
18	Getting started with Strategyzer	Learn how the Playbook Library works	Familiarity → Completely new / Know Strategyzer tools / Used platform	381 — Onboarding I
19	Getting started with Strategyzer	Learn more about the platform and AI	Progress → Done basics / Completed Onboarding I / Already using playbooks	382 — Onboarding II

Playbook Recommendations

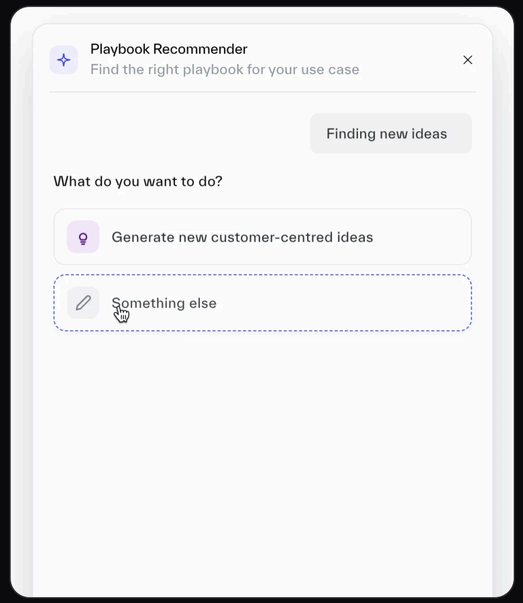
The working file. Every path mapped by hand.

Four small details that build trust.



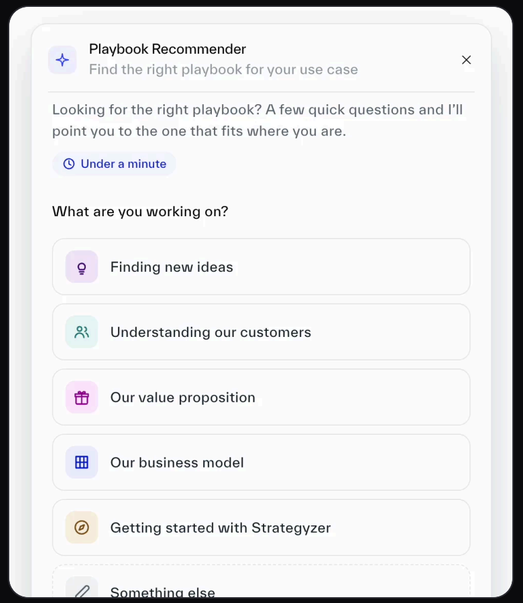
The panel stays the same size

It keeps one height, and the content scrolls inside. Early versions jumped with every answer.



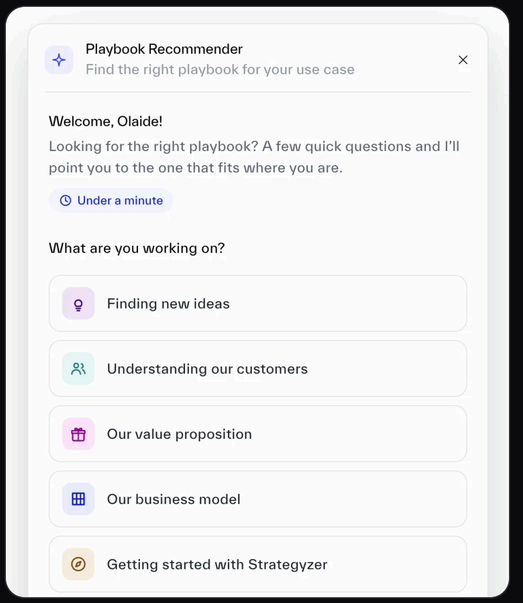
Change an answer without starting over

Click any earlier answer to edit it.



AI for everything else

Pick "Something else" and type your situation. AI finds the closest playbooks from the same map, so it only suggests real ones.

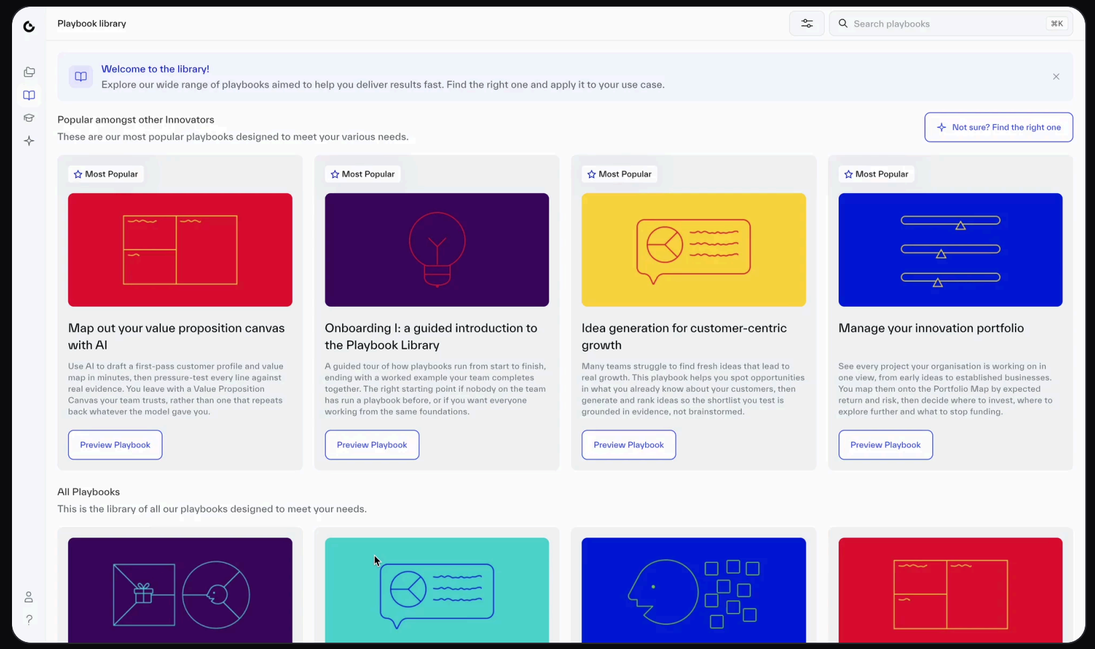


Honest when nothing fits

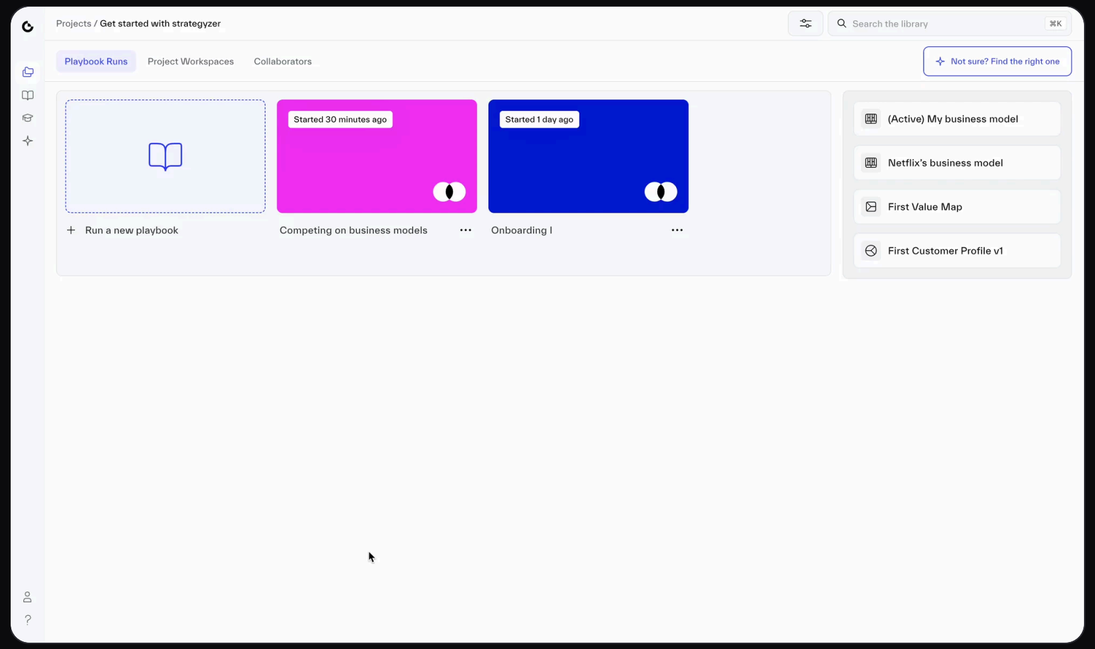
It says so and shows the closest options side by side. The hardest call in the project.

From stuck to started in about fifteen seconds.

STUCK — QUESTION 1 — QUESTION 2 — QUESTION 3 — **STARTED**



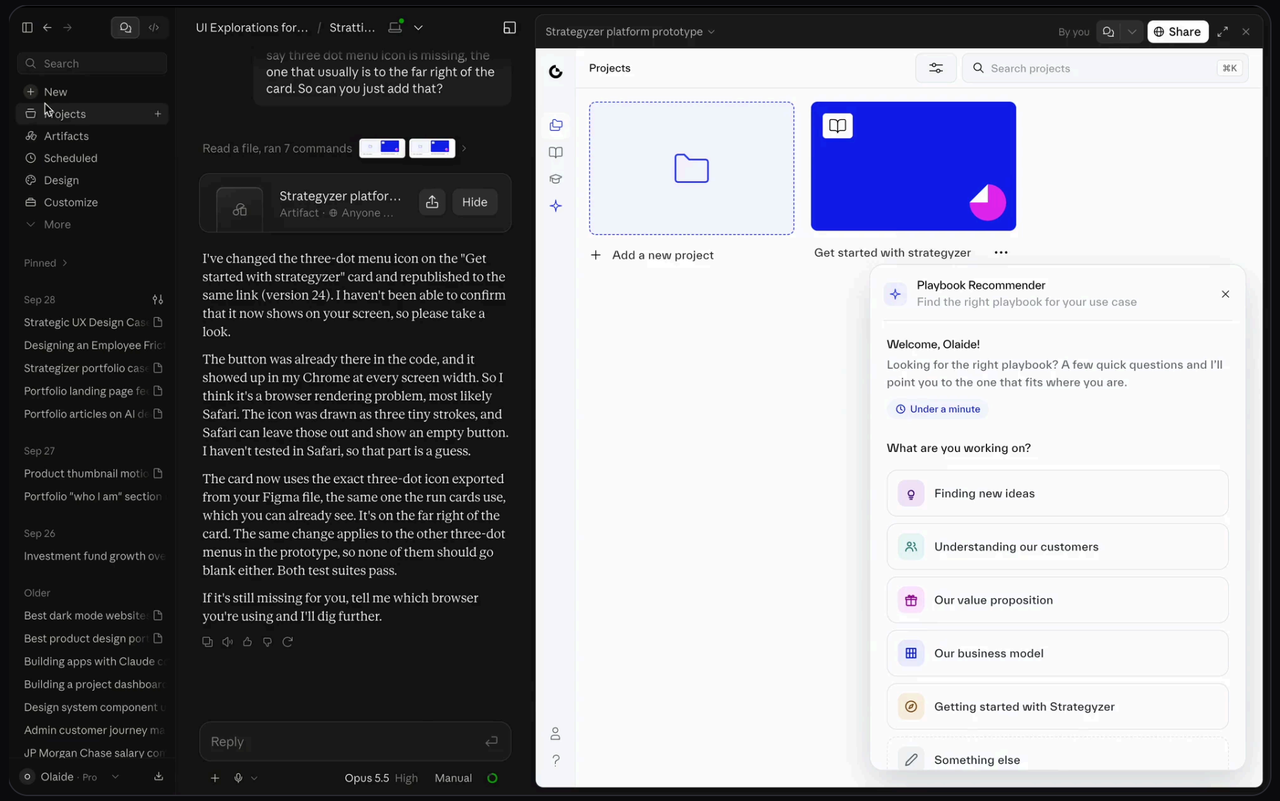
In the library, the results filter what's shown to the recommended playbooks.



Inside a project, one click on Add to this project adds the playbook and starts it.

TESTED AND BUILT IN CODE

Tested on the real thing, shipped as it was.



My conversation with Claude on the left, the working front end on the right.

about **24**

test sessions with coaches, customer teams and customers, about 8 each

BIGGEST CHANGE

I rewrote the questions so they were easier to understand, and so no one worried about picking the wrong answer.

ME	The front end, designed and built in code with Claude on FondUI. It's the code customers use today.
OUR ENGINEER	Everything behind it. Data, tracking and connecting it to the rest of the platform.

Research · 1-2 weeks	Assistant prototype · days	Question map · 2 days	Recommender built, tested, refined · 3 weeks	Launch · about 1½ weeks

About six weeks in total. Blue marks what I built in code with Claude.

RESULTS

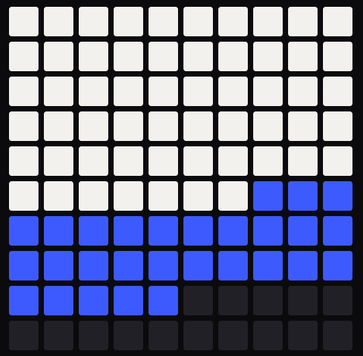
Fixing the first step moved every number that mattered.

Four months of data, comparing the months before and after launch.

QUOTE TO COME

A customer or stakeholder on the Recommender, in their exact words.

GETTING STARTED

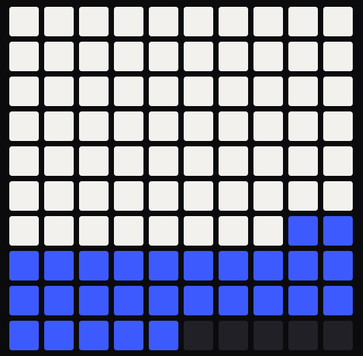


85%

was 57%

of new customers start a project and a playbook

SATISFACTION

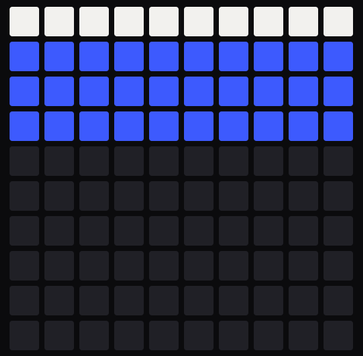


95%

was 68%

from customer surveys and our customer success team

COMING BACK · 4×



40%

was about 10%

return within 30 days of signing up. Most come back weekly.

CANCELLED, THEN RETURNED



about **18%**

after the release email

of cancelled customers came back to try it within two weeks

How we measured: product data for getting started and coming back, customer surveys and feedback for satisfaction

HOW WE WORK

From design to live in days.

What I built with Claude went live as it was. Our engineer connected it to the data behind it instead of rebuilding it from designs. The team now works at least twice as fast.



PRODUCT STRATEGY

The research found a missing playbook.

Mapping every customer need to a playbook showed a gap. Nothing helped people test whether customers want their offer, something many customers came to us needing. The Recommender says so instead of guessing, and the team that writes playbooks started on one straight away.

WHAT'S NEXT

I've recommended building Strattie AI, the assistant I prototyped at the start, to help at every step after the first. It's on the roadmap for the next year, and it can reuse the question map.

Shipping one focused thing first didn't shrink the vision. It made the case for it.